📜 US History Study Guide

StudyLab — Comprehensive Review

Table of Contents

1. Colonial America & the Road to Revolution (1607–1775)
2. Revolution & the New Nation (1775–1800)
3. Expansion, Reform & Sectionalism (1800–1860)
4. Civil War & Reconstruction (1861–1877)
5. Industrialization, Immigration & Progressivism (1877–1920)
6. World Wars, Cold War & Civil Rights (1920–1975)

Unit 1: Colonial America & the Road to Revolution (1607–1775)

The First Settlements

Jamestown (1607) was the first permanent English settlement, founded by the Virginia Company as a business venture. Early colonists nearly starved; survival came from tobacco cultivation and trade with the Powhatan Confederacy.

Plymouth (1620) was founded by the Pilgrims (Separatists) seeking religious freedom. The **Mayflower Compact** established self-governance — a landmark in democratic tradition.

Massachusetts Bay Colony (1630) was established by Puritans under John Winthrop, who described it as a "City upon a Hill" — a model community watched by the world.

Colonial Regions

Region	Colonies	Economy	Features
New England	MA, CT, RI, NH	Fishing, shipbuilding, trade	Town meetings, religious communities
Middle	NY, NJ, PA, DE	Grain ("breadbasket"), trade	Diverse, tolerant (especially PA)

Southern	VA, MD, NC, SC, GA	Cash crops, plantations	Slavery, aristocratic society

Road to Revolution

After the French and Indian War (1754–1763), Britain imposed new taxes on the colonies to pay war debts:

- **Stamp Act (1765)** — tax on printed materials; colonists protested "no taxation without representation"
- **Townshend Acts (1767)** — taxes on glass, lead, paint, paper, tea
- **Boston Massacre (1770)** — British soldiers killed 5 colonists; used as propaganda by patriots
- **Tea Act & Boston Tea Party (1773)** — colonists dumped tea into Boston Harbor
- **Intolerable Acts (1774)** — punished Massachusetts; united the colonies

> 💡 The First Continental Congress (1774) brought 12 of 13 colonies together for the first time.

Unit 2: Revolution & the New Nation (1775–1800)

The American Revolution

Fighting began at **Lexington and Concord** (April 1775). The **Declaration of Independence** (July 4, 1776), primarily authored by Thomas Jefferson, declared the colonies' separation from Britain based on Enlightenment ideals of natural rights.

Key turning points:

- **Battle of Saratoga (1777)** — American victory that convinced France to ally with the colonists
- **Valley Forge (1777–78)** — harsh winter camp where the Continental Army trained and grew stronger
- **Battle of Yorktown (1781)** — Washington's forces, with French help, defeated Cornwallis; effectively ended the war

Building the Government

The **Articles of Confederation** (1781) created a weak central government — no power to tax, no executive branch, no national courts. This led to problems like Shays' Rebellion (1786–87).

The **Constitutional Convention (1787)** in Philadelphia produced the U.S. Constitution with key compromises:

Issue	Compromise
Large vs. small states	**Great Compromise** — bicameral legislature (Senate + House)
Slavery & representation	**Three-Fifths Compromise** — enslaved people counted as 3/5 for representation
Executive power	Electoral College for presidential elections

Federalists vs. Anti-Federalists

- **Federalists** (Hamilton, Madison, Jay) — supported strong central government; wrote The Federalist Papers
- **Anti-Federalists** (Patrick Henry, George Mason) — feared central power; demanded a Bill of Rights

The **Bill of Rights** (1791) — first 10 amendments guaranteeing individual freedoms — secured ratification.

Unit 3: Expansion, Reform & Sectionalism (1800–1860)

Westward Expansion

- **Louisiana Purchase (1803)** — Jefferson doubled the nation's size for $15 million from France
- **Lewis and Clark Expedition (1804–06)** — explored the new territory to the Pacific
- **Manifest Destiny** — belief that American expansion across the continent was inevitable and divinely ordained
- **Indian Removal Act (1830)** — forced relocation of Native Americans; the Cherokee "Trail of Tears" killed thousands
- **Mexican-American War (1846–48)** — U.S. gained California, Nevada, Utah, Arizona, and parts of other states

Reform Movements

- **Abolitionism** — Frederick Douglass, Harriet Tubman (Underground Railroad), William Lloyd Garrison (The Liberator)
- **Women's Suffrage** — Seneca Falls Convention (1848), Elizabeth Cady Stanton & Susan B. Anthony
- **Temperance** — movement against alcohol consumption
- **Education Reform** — Horace Mann pushed for public schools

Growing Sectionalism

The fundamental divide: the industrial North vs. the agricultural, slave-dependent South.

- **Missouri Compromise (1820)** — admitted Missouri (slave) and Maine (free); drew the 36°30' line
- **Compromise of 1850** — California free; stronger Fugitive Slave Law
- **Kansas-Nebraska Act (1854)** — popular sovereignty in new territories; led to "Bleeding Kansas"
- **Dred Scott v. Sandford (1857)** — Supreme Court ruled enslaved people were not citizens

Unit 4: Civil War & Reconstruction (1861–1877)

Causes & Start of War

Abraham Lincoln's election in 1860 prompted 11 Southern states to secede and form the **Confederate States of America** under Jefferson Davis. The war began at **Fort Sumter** (April 1861).

Key Battles & Events

Event	Date	Significance
Bull Run	July 1861	First major battle; showed the war would be long
Antietam	Sept 1862	Bloodiest single day; led to Emancipation Proclamation
Emancipation Proclamation	Jan 1863	Freed slaves in rebel states; changed war's purpose
Gettysburg	July 1863	Turning point; Union victory in the East
Appomattox	April 1865	Lee surrendered to Grant; war ended

Reconstruction (1865–1877)

Three critical amendments:

- **13th Amendment (1865)** — abolished slavery
- **14th Amendment (1868)** — granted citizenship and equal protection
- **15th Amendment (1870)** — voting rights regardless of race

Reconstruction ended with the **Compromise of 1877** — federal troops withdrew from the South, leading to Jim Crow laws, sharecropping, and Black Codes that severely restricted Black Americans' rights for decades.

Unit 5: Industrialization, Immigration & Progressivism (1877–1920)

The Gilded Age

Rapid industrialization brought enormous wealth and extreme inequality. "Robber Barons" / "Captains of Industry":

- **Andrew Carnegie** — steel (vertical integration)
- **John D. Rockefeller** — oil/Standard Oil (horizontal integration)
- **J.P. Morgan** — banking and finance
- **Cornelius Vanderbilt** — railroads

Immigration & Urbanization

"New immigrants" (1880s–1920s) came primarily from Southern/Eastern Europe. They faced nativism and discrimination. **Ellis Island** processed millions of arrivals on the East Coast; **Angel Island** on the West Coast processed Asian immigrants.

Progressive Era (1890s–1920)

- **Muckrakers** — investigative journalists (Upton Sinclair's *The Jungle*, Ida Tarbell on Standard Oil)
- **Trust-busting** — Theodore Roosevelt used the Sherman Antitrust Act
- **16th Amendment (1913)** — federal income tax
- **17th Amendment (1913)** — direct election of senators
- **18th Amendment (1919)** — Prohibition (banned alcohol)
- **19th Amendment (1920)** — women's suffrage

Unit 6: World Wars, Cold War & Civil Rights (1920–1975)

World War I & The Roaring Twenties

The U.S. entered WWI in 1917 after unrestricted submarine warfare and the Zimmermann Telegram. The **Treaty of Versailles (1919)** imposed harsh terms on Germany; the U.S. Senate rejected the League of Nations.

The 1920s saw economic boom, jazz, flappers, and the Harlem Renaissance — followed by the **Stock Market Crash of 1929** and the Great Depression.

The New Deal & World War II

FDR's **New Deal** created Social Security, the FDIC, the SEC, and massive public works programs (CCC, WPA). WWII began for the U.S. after **Pearl Harbor (Dec 7, 1941)**.

Major events: D-Day (June 6, 1944), VE Day (May 1945), atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki (August 1945), VJ Day (Sept 1945).

The Cold War (1947–1991)

- **Truman Doctrine & Marshall Plan** — containing communism + rebuilding Europe
- **Korean War (1950–53)** — ended in stalemate at the 38th parallel
- **Cuban Missile Crisis (1962)** — closest the world came to nuclear war
- **Vietnam War (1955–1975)** — deeply divisive; ended with U.S. withdrawal

Civil Rights Movement (1950s–1960s)

- **Brown v. Board of Education (1954)** — overturned "separate but equal" in schools
- **Montgomery Bus Boycott (1955–56)** — sparked by Rosa Parks; led by Martin Luther King Jr.
- **March on Washington (1963)** — MLK's "I Have a Dream" speech
- **Civil Rights Act (1964)** — banned discrimination based on race, color, religion, sex, or national origin
- **Voting Rights Act (1965)** — eliminated barriers to Black voting

> 💡 The Civil Rights Movement used nonviolent protest (sit-ins, boycotts, marches) as its primary strategy, inspired by Gandhi.

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